

Network and Information Systems Security

From Control Frameworks to Advanced Architectures

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December 23, 2025

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1 The Security Framework: The Lifecycle

The de facto standard model for cybersecurity is the **NIST Cybersecurity Framework**, which defines five core functions to manage cyber risk:

1. **Identify:** Asset inventory, risk assessment, governance.
2. **Protect:** Access control, data protection, firewalls.
3. **Detect:** Continuous monitoring and intrusion detection.
4. **Respond:** Incident containment and mitigation.
5. **Recover:** Service restoration and patching.

2 The Firewall: Classification and Technologies

2.1 General Classifications

Firewalls can be classified based on their deployment architecture and placement:

- **Network Firewall vs Host-based Firewall:**

- *Network Firewall:* Protects the entire perimeter or specific network segments. It includes technologies such as **Packet Filters**, **Stateful Inspection**, **Proxies**, and **NGFWs**.
- *Host-based Firewall:* Protects a single endpoint (Server or PC). This includes **Personal Firewalls** and system **Hardening** practices.

- **Hardware vs Software:**

- *Hardware (Appliance):* Dedicated, high-performance physical devices. Modern perimeter **NGFWs** and **Packet Filters** are typically hardware-based appliances.
- *Software:* Desktop applications or service daemons installed on a general-purpose OS. **Proxies** (like Squid) and **Personal Firewalls** are typically software-based, though modern corporate Proxies are often embedded inside dedicated appliances (which remain subject to operating system exploits).

- **Perimeter vs Internal:**

- *Perimeter:* The choke point of contact between Internet and Intranet (or the DMZ). This is the standard location for **Packet Filters**, **Proxies**, and **NGFWs**.
- *Internal:* Protection established between internal departments or enforced locally on a single host (Hardening).

2.2 Packet Filtering (Stateless)

Operates at Layer 3 (Network) by inspecting individual IP packet headers.

- **Pros:** Extremely fast, low computing overhead.
- **Cons:** Low security threshold, complete lack of visibility into connection state or packet payloads.

2.2.1 Example of Filtering Rules (Rulebase)

A packet filter makes an action decision (Allow/Deny) based on a sequential lookup table. Logical layout example (an asterisk denotes ANY):

Action	Dir.	Source	Dest.	Proto	Comment
Block	In	Bad IP List	*	*	Block traffic from known malicious sources
Allow	Out	Internal Net	*	TCP	Allow outgoing web browsing and traffic
Allow	In	Any	Web Server	TCP 80	Public access to the official web server
Allow	In	Any	Mail Server	TCP 25	Incoming email reception via SMTP
Block	In	Any	Internal Net	*	<i>Default Deny</i> rule (Baseline security standard)

2.3 Stateful Inspection

Introduces the tracking mechanism called a **State Table**. The firewall remembers connection contexts, rejecting standalone **ACK** packets if a matching **SYN** packet was not processed previously (e.g., verifying "this incoming packet is an explicit reply to an outbound request sent 1 second ago").

- Operates at Layer 3 and Layer 4.
- Manages dynamic port connections (e.g., passive FTP) far better than a static packet filter.

2.4 Circuit-Level Gateway (Proxy)

Operates at Layer 5 (Session). It breaks the direct connection between client and server, acting as a active relay for the TCP handshake process.

2.4.1 Specific Protections of the Circuit-Level Proxy

By acting as an absolute intermediary for the session layer, it offers robust defenses against specific network attacks:

Attack Vector	Prevention Mechanism	Effectiveness
TCP SYN Flood (DoS)	The proxy completes the 3-way handshake with the external client before initiating a connection to the internal server. If the handshake fails, the internal server never receives packets.	High
IP Spoofing	Establishing a circuit requires a complete, bidirectional handshake. An attacker utilizing a spoofed IP address cannot receive the proxy's responses, causing the connection setup to fail.	High

TCP Session Hijacking	The proxy splits the network connection into two distinct segments with independent Sequence Numbers. The attacker cannot predict internal sequence tracking numbers.	High
Port Scanning	Topology Hiding: The proxy masks internal IP schemes. Scanners only see the external interface IP of the proxy itself.	High

2.5 Application Proxy and WAF

The highest tier of security is achieved using an Application-Level Gateway (Layer 7). Unlike packet filters that let network traffic stream through dynamically, the Proxy **breaks the raw connection**. It acts as a total intermediary, terminating the connection with the client and spawning a separate, new one toward the server (similar to a Circuit-Level Gateway), while thoroughly parsing the payload data.

2.5.1 Advantages and Disadvantages

This architectural choice provides unique security benefits but introduces significant operational trade-offs:

- **Advantages (Deep Security Enforcements):**
 - **Inherits all Layer 5 Circuit-Level Gateway advantages.**
 - **Encryption Decoupling (WAF: Web Application Firewall):** It can terminate inbound HTTPS traffic, inspect the raw cleartext payload for malicious signatures or injections, and re-encrypt the sanitized traffic to send it to the back-end internal server.
 - **Maximum Security Level:** Achieved by establishing full isolation between internal and external networks.
- **Disadvantages (Performance and Resource Overheads):**
 - **Setup Complexity:** There is no "one-size-fits-all" rule block. Every distinct service type (Web, Mail, FTP) requires a dedicated application proxy module and precise tuning matching the development evolutions of the app.
 - **Performance Bottleneck:** High computing overhead. Every packet must be re-assembled up to Layer 7, scrutinized, and re-encapsulated. This injects latency and demands powerful hardware configurations.

3 Summary Technology Comparison Table

The following matrix summarizes and compares different generations of firewall design choices:

Feature	Packet Filter	Stateful Inspection	Circuit Proxy	App. Proxy
OSI Layer	L3 (Network)	L3/L4 (Transport)	L5 (Session)	L7 (Application)
Inspection Focus	Single IP Headers	Connection Context	TCP Handshake	Payload / Content
Performance	Extremely Fast	Fast	Fast	Slow (High Overhead)
Security Layer	Low	Medium-High	Medium	Maximum Protection
Visibility Scope	Headers Only	Headers + State Logic	Handshake Only	Full Deep Inspection
Anonymization	None	Limited (via NAT)	Masks Topology	Absolute (Full Proxy)

4 Next-Generation Firewalls (NGFW)

The NGFW represents the modern paradigm of perimeter security. Rather than a simple boost in raw processing power, it introduces a structural transformation in how traffic is analyzed. While classic firewalls (Stateful L4) base filtering decisions on "who" (IP) and "where" (Port), the NGFW evaluates "what" (Application) and "who it actually is" (User Identity), embedding proactive threat prevention systems.

This architecture relies on three structural pillars:

1. Application Awareness (Layer 7 - App-ID):

- *The Core Problem:* In legacy firewalls, allowing port 80 (HTTP) meant inadvertently exposing the network to anything traveling over that port (HTTP tunneling, gaming, unauthorized file transfers).
- *The NGFW Solution:* The engine ignores port classifications and analyzes the raw data stream to extract unique **application signatures**. This allows granular policy enforcement: for instance, blocking "Facebook Games" and "Facebook Chat" while permitting "Facebook Base Navigation," even though all three flushes occur on the exact same TCP port.
- *Micro-segmentation:* Enables the platform to distinguish fine-grained functions within a single app environment (e.g., on Dropbox: enforcing "Download = Allow" alongside "Upload = Deny").

2. Native Integration (All-in-One & Single Pass Architecture):

- *Modular Consolidation:* The NGFW natively fuses security functionalities that historically demanded separate hardware appliances: **IPS** (Intrusion Prevention System), network antivirus engines, anti-spyware toolkits, and URL filtering databases.
- *Intrusion Prevention (IPS):* Unlike an IDS (which acts reactively), the IPS module inside a NGFW operates *in-line*: it inspects the live payload stream and actively discards packet bursts matching known exploit signatures or behavioral anomalies, killing the threat before it hits internal servers.
- *Single Pass Architecture:* Rather than processing a packet sequentially across independent systems (firewall engine → IPS device → Antivirus engine) which accumulates latency, the NGFW executes all scans simultaneously in a single memory pass. Individual security modules exchange context state instantly.

3. User Identity (User-ID):

- *Moving Beyond IP Addressing:* In modern enterprise environments (DHCP pools, Wi-Fi domains, BYOD devices), an IP address shifts constantly and fails to map safely to a single human user.
- *Directory Integration:* The NGFW directly links into central identity management systems (e.g., Microsoft Active Directory, LDAP).
- *Identity-based Policies:* Security rules are authored using real usernames and directory groups. Example: "Allow 'Marketing' group access to social media apps, but explicitly block the 'Interns' group", regardless of what device or current IP address they happen to use.

5 Network Architecture: DMZs and Traffic Flows

Perimeter security is not built around a single defensive box, but relies on segmenting networks into zones with varying *Trust Levels*. The standard implementation layout is the **Screened Subnet**, commonly referred to as a DMZ (**Demilitarized Zone**).

5.1 Traffic Flow Logic (Policy Enforcement)

Following the principle of *Least Privilege* applied to network routing, firewall configurations must enforce strict directional boundaries:

- **Intranet → Internet (Outbound):** Generally permitted, yet heavily filtered. Internal hosts can reach the outside web (HTTP/HTTPS), frequently routed through a *Forward Proxy* for content analysis and caching tasks.
- **Internet → DMZ (Inbound Public):** Exclusively allowed toward specialized exposed assets (Bastion Hosts). The external perimeteric firewall only opens explicitly defined ports (e.g., 80/443 for Web servers, 25 for SMTP mail relays) pointing to public DMZ IPs. All other packets are silently *Dropped*.
- **Internet → Intranet: Strictly Forbidden.** No direct routing paths should ever exist that allow a packet from the public Internet to cross into the internal secure intranet zone without intermediate sanitization.
- **DMZ → Intranet:** This is the most critical junction. By default, all traffic is **blocked**. If a public-facing Web Server sitting in the DMZ is compromised, the attacker must be stopped from executing a lateral pivot into the internal enterprise network. *Exceptions:* If a DMZ Web Server must query an internal database, a tightly scoped "pinhole rule" is introduced, restricted to that exact port (e.g., TCP 3306) between two specific static IP nodes.
- **DMZ → Internet:** Allowed for automated repository patching or requested connection responses, but limited to prevent a compromised server from establishing Command & Control (C&C) botnet channels.

5.2 The "Composite Firewall" Architecture (Screened Subnet)

For robust *Enterprise* deployments, organizations rely on a multi-tiered layer of defense (*Defense in Depth*), forcing intruders to crack multiple technological gates. Following the corporate architectural blueprint:

1. **Exterior Router (Packet Filtering):** The first perimeteric checkpoint. It performs brute Layer 3/Layer 4 filtering to drop IP spoofing attempts, useless broadcast storms, and unmapped network protocols. It shields the main firewall appliances from processing exhaustion.
2. **Gateway Firewall / Bastion Host:** Deployed between the external router and the DMZ boundary. It is often an **Application Proxy** or a high-end NGFW handling full Layer 7 deep packet analysis. It terminates TLS sessions and manages public services.
3. **Perimeter Network (DMZ):** The isolated buffer zone hosting publicly reachable servers. These nodes are hardened to extreme standards since they occupy an exposed network position.

4. **Interior Firewall:** The highest priority component. It cuts off the DMZ from the Internal Intranet and sensitive corporate business domains (e.g., the Finance Group).
 - **The Principle of Vendor Diversification:** It is a strict *Best Practice* to deploy different hardware vendors for the external and internal firewalls. If an attacker leverages an unpatched *Zero-Day* vulnerability to bypass the perimeter gate, that exact same exploit will fail against the internal firewall.

6 Operating System Hardening

Deploying network firewalls is useless if the target hosts are inherently vulnerable. **Hardening** is the systematic process of reducing a computer system's structural *Attack Surface*.

6.1 Core Principles and Engineering Steps

- **Service Minimization (Service Reduction):** Simply "not using" a service is insufficient. If a daemon background process (e.g., FTP, Telnet, RPC) is active and bound to a port, it is exposed to exploits. *Action:* Disable unnecessary services from booting (e.g., `systemctl disable`), strip unneeded binaries from the system, and close unmapped ports. "What does not exist cannot be compromised".
- **Account & Access Management:**
 - Eradicate or rename default out-of-the-box accounts (Guest, Administrator, pi).
 - Enforce the rule of *Least Privilege*: web daemons must never run with root privileges, but under restricted, dedicated users (e.g., `www-data`).
 - Enforce strong password complexity rules and mandatory rotation schedules.
- **Proactive Patch Management:** The vast majority of automated attacks exploit well-documented vulnerabilities for which patches have already been published (*N-Day* vulnerabilities). A system left unpatched 24-48 hours after a critical security patch release becomes highly vulnerable.
- **Logging and Audit (Non-Repudiation):** In a post-breach scenario, logs are the ultimate source of forensics truth. *Advanced Architecture setup:* Logs must never reside purely on the local machine (where an intruder can wipe them to erase tracks). They must stream in real-time via `syslog` to an isolated, immutable remote tracking platform (Log Server / SIEM).
- **File System Integrity:** Mount core system partitions (e.g., `/boot`, `/usr`) in *Read-Only* mode wherever possible. Inject flags like `noexec` on volatile scratch folders (`/tmp`) to block execution of binary scripts dropped by an attacker.

7 Detection and Prevention Systems (IDS/IPS)

Once a perimeter firewall has been crossed, a system of internal surveillance is required. This is the domain of IDS and IPS engines (split into Network and Host variants).

7.1 Conceptual Blueprint: IDS vs IPS

- **IDS (Intrusion Detection System):** A passive monitoring sensor ("Burglar Alarm style").
 - Scrutinizes payload packet traffic or system log streams.
 - Fires off a structural alert to an administrator or the central SIEM when anomalies spark.
 - **Does not block** network traffic. It operates "Out-of-Band" (analyzing a cloned stream via port mirroring/SPAN ports).
- **IPS (Intrusion Prevention System):** An active mitigation actuator ("Bouncer style").
 - Positioned directly "In-Line" (live traffic physically flows through the engine).
 - Instantly terminates an active exploit wave (dropping packets, executing TCP resets).
 - Operational Risk: A single *false positive* will drop legitimate traffic, inducing a self-inflicted Denial of Service.

7.1.1 Network-Based Implementations (NIDS and NIPS)

These tools analyze packet streams "on-the-wire" as they cross the network fabric.

- **NIDS (Network Intrusion Detection System):**
 - **Definition:** An IDS monitoring a network section, acting like a security camera feed.
 - **Mechanism:** The sniffing network interface card runs in "Promiscuous Mode." It ingests a *copy* of traffic (cloned via SPAN/Port Mirroring on a core switch) without touching the latency of the actual data lines.
 - **Contrast with IPS:** If the NIDS spots a signature hit, it logs an alert, but the exploit payload still reaches its target because the sensor lives entirely Out-of-Band.
- **NIPS (Network Intrusion Prevention System):**
 - **Definition:** An IPS deployed directly inside the routing stream, acting like a customs checkpoint.
 - **Mechanism:** Deployed strictly *In-Line*. Data packets cannot transit without passing through the NIPS engine inspection cycles first.
 - **Contrast with IDS:** If the NIPS flags a signature anomaly, it drops that packet burst instantly. The malicious byte string never reaches its destination.

7.1.2 Host-Based Implementations (HIDS and HIPS)

Software engines (Agents) installed directly onto single core servers or corporate endpoints.

- **Monitoring Capabilities:** They track activity happening *inside* the machine: system file changes (File Integrity Monitoring), OS event logs, active process memory allocations.
- **Edge over Network Sensors:** They scan payload flows *after* network encryption layers are stripped (e.g., after HTTPS decryption) and can intercept local hardware-based vectors (e.g., malicious USB insertions).

7.2 Detection Engines

How do surveillance tools identify an ongoing attack?

7.2.1 1. Signature-Based Engine

Compares network payloads against a static database of known attack fingerprints (matching classic antivirus logic).

- **Pros:** Blazing fast processing speeds, low rate of false positives.
- **Cons:** Blind to undiscovered *Zero-Day* vectors or advanced polymorphic malware code.

7.2.2 2. Anomaly-Based Engine (Behavioral)

Baselines normal operational patterns of user networks over time and highlights statistical outliers. The system profiles routine patterns by tracking key vectors:

- **Activity & Time:** Mapping a login event at 3:00 AM for a user who strictly works a 9-to-5 schedule.
- **Data Volume:** Spotting a server blasting 10GB of raw compressed data toward an unmapped foreign IP node (detecting active data exfiltration).
- **Application Usage:** A non-technical administrative profile executing advanced PowerShell commands.
- **Location:** Catching dual logins from Rome and Tokyo within a tiny time window (Impossible Travel anomaly).
- **Pros:** Capable of exposing unmapped Zero-Days and stolen credential abuses.
- **Cons:** High frequency of false positives (a simple shift in corporate operations can trigger security alerts).

8 Security Operations Management (SOC & SIEM)

Securing a modern corporate infrastructure demands an operational team structure alongside technical software.

8.1 SOC (Security Operations Center)

The SOC is a centralized facility hosting the infrastructure responsible for monitoring, analyzing, and defending organizational perimeters 24/7. It represents an ****operational capacity**** fueled by three key pillars:

1. **People:** Security analysts (categorized into Tiers 1, 2, and 3) who ingest and interpret alert flows.
2. **Processes:** Structured response books (*Playbooks*) dictating exactly how to contain an outbreak (e.g., "Ransomware Containment Playbook steps").
3. **Technology:** The underlying engineering stack that correlates data and stops threats (SIEM, NGFW, EDR tools).

Core Mandate of the SOC: Reducing the time delta separating initial breach from execution neutralization (*Time to Detect* and *Time to Respond*).

8.2 SIEM (Security Information and Event Management)

If the SOC is the command team, the SIEM engine is their multi-screen cockpit dashboard. Because modern companies deploy dozens of disparate security tools (Firewalls, Antivirus suites, Proxies, IDSes), a human analyst cannot review their standalone output manually in real-time.

The SIEM solves this layout issue across three systematic core steps:

- **Aggregation:** Ingests and centralizes log feeds from all enterprise components (network appliances, operating systems, cloud applications, database pools).
- **Normalization:** Translates disparate input types (Cisco Syslog strings, Windows Event-Log XMLs, AWS CloudTrail JSONs) into a unified, clean schema format.
- **Correlation (The Intelligence Layer):** Analyzes separate, scattered log points to tie together events that look innocent standalone but signify an attack chain when linked.

Correlation Example:

- Event A: "5 sequential login failures on perimeter firewall" (Brute Force attempt).
- Event B: "1 successful login on the VPN gateway 2 seconds later" (Stolen access).
- Event C: "New administrative account created on the active Domain Controller".
- **SIEM Logic Action:** Connects the dots and triggers an immediate **High-Severity Incident Alert** for credential theft and privilege escalation.

8.3 Organizational Structures: SOC vs NOC vs CSIRT

Entity	Core Functional Focus	Primary Operational Goal
NOC (Network Operations Center)	Availability and Performance. Tracks bandwidth thresholds, line latencies, and device status.	Enforce strict uptime SLA agreements and overall Quality of Service (QoS).
SOC (Security Operations Center)	Security and Threats. Intercepts active network attacks, data breaches, and endpoint malware.	Detect, triage, analyze, and neutralize corporate security incidents.
CSIRT / CERT (Computer Security Incident Response Team)	Incident Response Execution. Specialized blue-team asset deploying directly "during the fire".	Advanced digital forensics, strict containment execution, and system disaster recovery.

8.4 SOC Tiers (Analyst Hierarchy)

SOC operations segment personnel across three tiered skill groups:

1. **Tier 1 (Triage Analyst):** Constantly filters incoming SIEM dashboards. Strips out false positives, handles routine alerts, and scales advanced attacks up the chain. (An engineering level heavily augmented by AI automation).
2. **Tier 2 (Incident Responder):** Ingests escalated critical threats. Performs rigorous *Root Cause Analysis*, gauges compromise perimeters, and issues containment actions.
3. **Tier 3 (Threat Hunter / Expert Senior):** Proactive security researchers. Rather than waiting on dashboard alerts, they dig into raw log lakes hunting hidden, silent anomalies (*Threat Hunting*). They execute low-level Malware Disassembly and complex Digital Forensics.

10 Data and Privacy: Identification and Obfuscation

10.1 PII (Personally Identifiable Information)

Modern system continuous monitoring logs process highly sensitive data. It is fundamental to segment:

- **PII (Direct Identifiers):** Data strings capable of mapping uniquely to a single individual person (Full Name, National Identity ID, Credit Card Numbers, Personal Email addresses, biometric markers). Enforced via maximum regulatory frameworks (GDPR).
- **Non-PII / Linked Data:** Telemetry points that fail to pinpoint an identity standalone (e.g., "Gender: Male", "City: Milan", "Browser type: Firefox"), yet when combined via advanced analytical correlations (*Data Linkage*) can generate full *Re-identification* of the corporate subject (de-anonymization attack paths).

10.2 Steganography

While **Cryptography** scrambled the raw message content making it unreadable (masking the context meaning), **Steganography** renders the message footprint entirely **invisible** (masking the structural existence of the communication channel itself).

- **Classic Technique (LSB - Least Significant Bit):** Modifies the least significant bits of color arrays inside standard carrier files. *Mechanism:* Inside a typical 24-bit RGB photo, turning the trailing bit of color bytes shifts values across minor gradients entirely imperceptible to human sight, allowing engineers to hide complete system configurations or malware scripts inside a standard pixel image frame.
- **Cybersecurity Deployments:**
 - *Offensive Vectors:* Sophisticated malware strains pulling encrypted C&C parameters buried inside vanilla site logos to cleanly evade network perimeter IPS controls.
 - *Defensive Enforcements:* Injecting unique digital markers into sensitive documents for tracking purposes (DLP - Data Loss Prevention).

10.2.1 Defensive Strategy Use Cases

1. **Digital Fingerprinting (Traitor Tracing):** The standard engineering mechanism deployed across highly confidential corporate or defense operations.
 - *Scenario Setup:* An enterprise must distribute a sensitive document draft across 50 internal directors.
 - *Engineering Mechanism:* The script renders a unique copy tailored for each specific user, embedding a custom invisible ID invisibly (e.g., adjusting micro-spacings between characters or color LSB values inside a corporate header icon).
 - *Defense Vector:* If a leak occurs and a photo of the page surfaces on media outlets, security engineers extract the document, parse the hidden ID, and determine the exact person responsible for the data loss (Non-Repudiation tracking).
2. **Fragile Watermarking (Integrity Enforcements):** Designed to detect unauthorized content tampering.

- *Mechanism:* A delicate, "fragile" watermark structure is embedded into files like forensic images or CCTV camera evidence logs.
 - *Defense:* This signature is mathematically designed to corrupt completely if even a single bit of the file container is modified. If a file is audited during legal validation and the watermark fails to decode, the asset is flagged as altered, invalidating its authenticity.
3. **Honeytokens (Traps):** Using steganographic embedding to drop active traps within internal file directories.
- *Defense:* Security teams plant fake administrative credential strings inside seemingly critical file objects via steganography. No standard employee would ever read or query them. If the SIEM logs a login attempt using those specific bait credentials, it triggers an immediate alert: a malicious actor is actively harvesting file systems and has tripped a landmine.

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Overview:
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Integrated
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